

Stuck in the box

January is typically an exciting month for geeks, thanks to CES Las Vegas, and all the hype surrounding it. For good reason too, because it's one of the world's largest technology fairs, and is quite reliable as a way to predict the year ahead.

Everyone expected tablet PCs running Google's Android to be in abundance at CES, and they were – over 70 new tablets were launched. It's obvious that tablets are going to hit you smack in the face this year, with all and sundry throwing irresistible offers your way. No surprises there.

Intel finally unveiled its Sandy Bridge chips to the world, but we'd already had them in our labs for over a month, waiting only for the confidentiality embargo to pass so that we could share the test results with you.

3DTVs and 3D entertainment were the other big talking points, but then as Digit readers, you're probably already bored of all the 3D. "Where's the content?", you hear yourself scream – in frustration. Plus, with so many people feeling dizzy after staring at 3D displays for extended periods, it's probably not a really exciting topic for you... not until they do away with those stupid glasses...

Then there was the fact that everything portable got smaller, or at least more powerful; screens for your home got bigger, but sleeker; Microsoft promised us the world with Kinect; every gadget seemed to be capable of having an IP address (IPv6 here we come); and world hunger was eradicated (not!).

So basically, everything got smaller/bigger, it's all converging online, all faster, all new and yet all old at the same time... it's like the technology world's plateaued, and everything is the next big thing, and yet none of it really is.

Of course, you've probably read a hundred reports about it already, and most (or all) of them will have waxed eloquent about how this year's edition was "even better than last year" (isn't it always?), and how "there are exciting times ahead", and more clichés than you can handle. Heck the story on CES in this very issue of Digit has one or two of those thrown in for good measure.

Personally, I'm looking forward to colour e-ink like screens the most. We tested a few monochrome ones this month, and anything that can offer a month of battery standby, and close to

a week worth of reading gets my vote. Throw in a colour screen, and I'm even happier. However, companies are now trying to tack touch screens on to these readers and completely losing the plot. Some categories just shouldn't converge...

Another reason why colour e-ink screens grab my attention is because they're the best bet to replacing paper, especially magazines – we'll have an ebook version of Digit before you know it.

So what did we learn from CES? The same thing we've been seeing for years I suppose – brands falling over themselves to be the next Apple iPod, trying to part us fools from our money for devices we really don't need, but most certainly "must have". Is that the future of technology? Gadgets, gizmos, web services and more that play on our narcissistic streaks and need to impress others?

Are we all just destined to become fat, lazy, blobs of flesh who just consume, consume, consume? Save us WALL-E!

We certainly hope not, and that's why Digit will try its best to keep showcasing exactly what the future *should* be.

This month, we spent a lot more time discussing the utopian world of the Venus Project than the latest at CES, which was a pleasant change. Although I think the Venus Project is an idea that's a few hundred years before its time, it's still an interesting concept that has technology and its rapid development at its core. At least *someone* is trying to solve world hunger using technology, instead of thinking only profits... Turn to page 38 to read the whole story.

What we at Digit hope to be able to do more successfully this year, is to challenge you to think out of the box, and expose you to new ideas – one article at a time. And even though you may feel that ideas such as the Venus Project are "the result of smoking too much pot", remind yourself that it was similar stuck-in-the-box thinking that led to infamous foot-in-mouth quotes such as: "640K ought to be enough for anybody", "...there is a world market for maybe five computers", and my favourite, "Everything that can be invented has been invented"! 



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Liked or hated the views in this column? Write in to me and express your own opinions and ideas.